

Architectural styles

EARLY ISLAMIC

Initially influenced by existing architectural traditions—notably the Classical and Byzantine—early Islamic architecture soon developed its own characteristics, which would lead to the creation of some of the world's greatest and most enduring monuments.

The mosque is the defining building of Islamic architecture. Primarily a place of worship, it is also a social and cultural center, and in many instances a place of education for all ages. The heart of the mosque is the prayer hall, a typically large space often supported by rows of columns and sometimes topped by a dome. Outside, mosques usually include a large courtyard with colonnades on each side, sometimes accompanied by a fountain, as well as a minaret—a tower clearly visible from the surrounding area and from where the faithful are called to prayer.

The Islamic faith prohibits depictions of human and animal forms in religious art and architecture, and as a result, Islamic culture evolved highly sophisticated decorative languages of geometry and pattern. These are sometimes combined with calligraphic inscriptions from the Qur'an. In addition to surface decoration, many Islamic buildings are ornamented by muqarnas—subdivisions of the underside of a dome or vault that create a honeycomb effect, as seen most dramatically in the Alhambra in Granada, Spain.

vegetal patterns weave around geometric designs

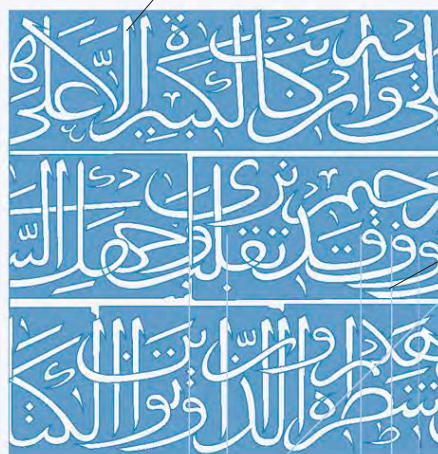
mosaics also feature jewels and crowns



△ GEOMETRIC PATTERNS

Intricate geometric patterns are typically formed from intersecting circles and squares, with multiple overlays building up the complexity.

calligraphy is often the dominant decorative element



Arabic script has an aesthetic appeal

△ CALLIGRAPHY

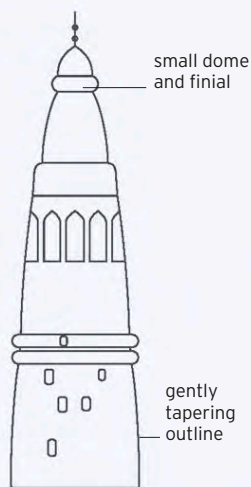
Calligraphy is central to Islamic culture. Although linked to the Qur'an, from which it emerged, Islamic calligraphy is not limited to religious texts but is also used in cultural forms such as poetry.

octagonal shape may be based on polygonal Byzantine shrines

tiles are usually in blues, greens, and turquoise

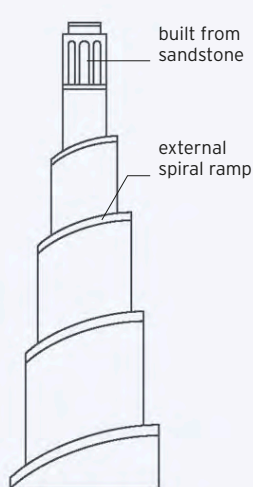
four doors facing the cardinal points lead to the interior

MINARETS



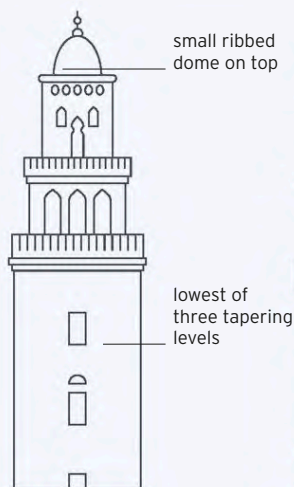
△ YEMENI MINARET

In this form, the different levels of the minaret are integrated into one single tapering form topped by a small dome.



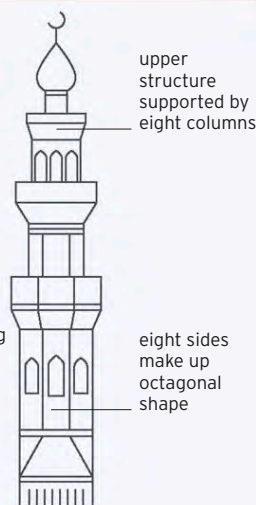
△ AL MUTAWAKIL MOSQUE

The spiraling conical form is unusual; it might reflect the importance of the mosque, which was one of the largest in the world when built.



△ KAIROUAN MOSQUE

With a square base and squat in appearance, this simple minaret design proved highly influential in mosque design.



△ SULTAN HASAN MOSQUE

Standing in the old city of Cairo, the three octagonal minarets are tightly integrated into the structure and design of the mosque.

▲ DOME OF THE ROCK

One of the oldest extant works of Islamic architecture, the Dome of the Rock is a shrine located on the Temple Mount in Old Jerusalem. Its gilded dome borrows heavily from Byzantine architecture, although its geometric decoration is characteristically Islamic.